Bipartisan Campaign Messages Are Credible Signals of Bipartisan Lawmaking*

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Abstract

Bipartisan cooperation is crucial for congressional productivity and democratic legitimacy, yet bipartisan campaign rhetoric is often dismissed as an electioneering tactic. If these appeals are simply "cheap talk," they reveal little about how candidates will govern, weakening the representational link between campaigning and lawmaking. We argue instead that campaign messages do credibly signal bipartisan intent, but that bipartisan lawmaking is concentrated in policy areas where candidates make bipartisan appeals. To test this theory of selective bipartisan lawmaking, we link policy-specific bipartisan campaign messages from U.S. House candidates (N=43,465; 2018–2022) to sponsorship and cosponsorship of related bills in the 116th–118th Congresses. We demonstrate that candidates who highlight bipartisan cooperation in specific policy areas while campaigning are more likely to engage in meaningful cross-party policymaking once in office and achieve greater legislative success in those same domains. Our findings clarify the policy-specific structure of bipartisan lawmaking in a polarized era.

Keywords: Bipartisanship, Representation, Campaigns, Text-as-Data

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Bipartisan cooperation is both frequent and consequential in the United States Congress. Although congressional dysfunction dominates media and scholarly attention, cross-party collaboration remains a pervasive approach to lawmaking (Curry and Lee 2020). This cooperation drives policymaking success: bipartisan bills advance through the legislative process at higher rates, and most enacted laws secure cross-party support (e.g., Mayhew 1991; Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023; Craig 2023). Bipartisan initiatives also tend to generate greater public approval than partisan efforts, reinforcing confidence in Congress as an institution (e.g., Curry 2019; Wolak 2020; Hetherington and Rudolph 2015). Cross-party cooperation thus serves as a cornerstone of congressional productivity and democratic legitimacy.

Given these stakes, congressional candidates have strong incentives to invoke bipartisanship on the campaign trail. Bipartisan rhetoric allows candidates to frame their policy goals as achievable within an increasingly polarized legislature by signaling a willingness to build the cross-party coalitions often necessary for legislative success. When such electoral rhetoric corresponds with legislative behavior, campaigns provide credible signals of candidates' governing intentions. These dynamics of promise-making and promise-keeping are central to democratic representation. Bipartisan appeals establish public commitments about how candidates propose to govern, while legislative behavior reveals whether elected officials act in accordance with those commitments.

Bipartisan campaign messages, however, are widely regarded as unreliable signals of governing intentions. Existing research suggests that bipartisan campaign rhetoric is uncommon, even among legislators known for working across the aisle (Gutmann and Thompson 2014; Anderson, Butler and Harbridge-Yong 2020). When bipartisan messaging does occur, other work finds no consistent link to bipartisan legislative action (e.g., Westwood 2022; Dobson, Volden and Wiseman 2025). Such findings reinforce the conclusion that bipartisan messaging is "cheap talk," aimed at expanding electoral appeal rather than a signal of lawmaking commitments (Trubowitz and Mellow 2005). This gap between messaging and legislating carries significant implications. When campaign appeals do not reliably correspond to legislative behavior, elected officials fall short of their normative duty to make governing intentions legible and accountable (Mansbridge 2003; Rehfeld 2009).

We challenge this prevailing view by arguing that bipartisan campaign messages serve as credible signals of the policy domains in which legislators prioritize cross-party collaboration. Existing literature conceptualizes bipartisan lawmaking as a stable orientation toward working across party lines (e.g., Harbridge 2015; Lugar and Montgomery 2015; Curry and Roberts 2025). We argue, by contrast, that bipartisan campaign commitments should be understood as tied to issue priorities (e.g., healthcare or immigration), rather than generic statements about a disposition toward cooperation unconstrained to a policy domain. We also posit that these appeals are selective: legislators invoke cross-party collaboration when discussing some issue priorities but not others, and these appeals signal the policy domains in which legislators intend to pursue inter-party collaboration once in office. We test this theory by examining whether the policy domains candidates link to bipartisan campaign appeals are associated with patterns of cross-party legislative cooperation.

To evaluate whether bipartisan campaign commitments credibly signal legislative behavior, we analyze policy messaging in U.S. House candidates' campaign platforms from 2018 to 2022 (N = 43,465). Using a supervised machine learning pipeline, we identify bipartisan appeals across the issue priorities emphasized in these platforms. We then assess whether legislators exhibit greater cross-party collaboration in the policy domains associated with their bipartisan campaign appeals in the 116th–118th Congresses (2019–2024; N = 23,647), operationalizing bipartisan engagement through bill sponsorship and cosponsorship patterns.

Our descriptive analyses provide support for the expectation that bipartisan campaign messaging is both prevalent and tied to candidates' issue priorities. Nearly half of all incumbents—across a range of electoral contexts—incorporate bipartisan appeals into their campaign platforms, suggesting that candidates' use of bipartisan rhetoric is not constrained to only those seeking to broaden their electoral appeal. At the same time, candidates are selective, with most confining their bipartisan appeals to one or two policy domains within their campaign platform. These appeals, however, span a broad range of policy domains, including contentious areas such as healthcare and environmental policy. This targeted, uneven application of bipartisan rhetoric suggests that candidates treat such appeals as selective signals rather than a general commitment to cross-party collaboration.

Using regression-based analyses, we examine (1) whether bipartisan campaign commitments tied to candidates' issue priorities signal cross-party lawmaking behavior, and (2) whether these commitments reflect substantive participation in crafting bipartisan legislation rather than "cheap talk," or low-cost legislative engagement with their peers across the aisle. Our models include member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects, allowing us to compare a legislator's bipartisan engagement across policy areas within the same Congress while accounting for policy-specific shocks and agenda dynamics within each Congress. We find that legislators exhibit greater cross-party collaboration in policy domains where their campaign messaging is bipartisan. Importantly, this relationship is driven by substantive bipartisan engagement—sponsoring and originally cosponsoring legislation, reflecting a genuine collaboration across party lines—rather than lower-cost forms of bipartisan engagement. Effect sizes are substantively meaningful, comparable in magnitude to other major predictors of bipartisan behavior. Finally, we show that this selective collaboration is associated with legislative success: politicians who engage in substantive bipartisan collaboration are more likely to see their sponsored or originally cosponsored legislation in the relevant policy domain pass the House and become law.

These findings deepen our understanding of the link between campaign rhetoric and legislative behavior. Bipartisan appeals—often dismissed as either absent from campaigns or as electioneering tactics—are credible signals of lawmaking behavior. This suggests that politicians view bipartisanship instrumentally, as a strategic tool for achieving policy goals. These findings also challenge normative critiques that argue campaigns obscure rather than illuminate governing behavior. The campaign-to-Congress connection we document suggests that representatives often satisfy their normative duty to align their bipartisan electoral commitments with legislative conduct.

Our selective bipartisanship framework also reconciles an apparent tension in the literature: polarization dominates contemporary lawmaking, yet meaningful bipartisan cooperation persists. This framework shows that legislators cooperate selectively in policy domains where cross-party incentives align—consistent with Levendusky's (2023) observation that "it may not be possible to bridge the gap on every issue, but there are cases where compromise and coming together is

possible, and finding those pathways is worthwhile" (p. 154). Rather than implying that broad depolarization is necessary for a productive legislature, our findings identify the policy-defined pathways through which cross-party cooperation remains viable. Representative democracy can function amid polarization—not through sweeping consensus, but through targeted commitments candidates attach to issue priorities, where compromise serves to advance their policymaking goals.

The Promise and Practice of Bipartisan Lawmaking

Theories of representation and related empirical work offer several accounts of why campaign promises may structure elected officials' behavior in office. Representatives may keep campaign promises because voters penalize broken promises (e.g., Matthieß 2020; Naurin, Soroka and Markwat 2019) and, even if sanctions are uncertain, the perceived risk of electoral punishment from constituents can motivate promise-keeping (Tomz and Van Houweling 2009). Risk-averse legislators may also avoid deviation to preempt costs imposed by other attentive observers, including donors, campaign opponents, the media, and legislative partners (e.g., Arnold 1990; Bawn et al. 2012; Bernhard and Sulkin 2013). Campaign promises also carry normative force. As Mansbridge (2003) argues and Rehfeld (2009) clarifies, the promissory representative "has a 'normative duty to keep promises' quite apart from fearing the electoral sanction he or she is sure to face" (p. 220). In this account, imperfect electoral sanctioning does not diminish the democratic significance of promise-keeping because accountability inheres in the public commitment itself and the normative obligation it imposes on the representative to follow through.

Within this promissory framework, the link between campaign commitments and legislative behavior is typically examined by asking whether legislators pursue action on the issues they prioritized as candidates. Previous research finds that candidates adopt clear issue priorities on the campaign trail (e.g., Sides 2006; Milita, Ryan and Simas 2014) and that legislators do actively pursue those priorities once in office (e.g., Sulkin 2009, 2011; Thomson et al. 2017). Issue priorities, however, represent only one dimension of promissory representation. Candidates can also make commitments about their intended approach to lawmaking, including their orientation toward bipartisanship—defined here as cooperation between members of opposing parties to enact public

policy. Whereas issue emphasis indicates *what* policy domains a candidate prioritizes, bipartisan messaging speaks to *how* candidates intend to advance those priorities.

Whether bipartisan campaign commitments signal lawmaking behavior has significant consequences, not only for the promissory link between campaigns and governance, but also for public evaluations of Congress and the policy-making process. Public opinion research shows that Americans prefer bipartisan legislative processes and policy outcomes (e.g., Harbridge and Malhotra 2011; Noel 2016; Bauer, Harbridge-Yong and Krupnikov 2017; Curry 2019; Anderson, Butler and Harbridge-Yong 2020; Wolak 2020; Hopkins, Lendway and Sigler 2025). Moreover, structural features of the U.S. system rarely give either party both the margins and internal cohesion needed to govern unilaterally (Krehbiel 1998; Mayhew 1991). As a result, legislation most often passes with broad cross-party support, even in today's polarized environment (Curry and Lee 2020), making bipartisan coalition-building central to legislative success. Consistent with these dynamics, Americans are twice as likely to favor politicians who compromise across party lines to advance legislation over those whose ideological rigidity limits policy gains (Gallup 2025).

Despite these stakes, existing research suggests that politicians rarely signal bipartisan intentions during campaigns. As Gutmann and Thompson (2014) argue, even legislators predisposed to cross-party collaboration avoid emphasizing compromise because "a successful campaign strategy requires the opposite of a compromising mindset. It favors candidates who…condemn their opponents' positions at every turn" (p. 160). In this view, bipartisan messaging is electorally risky because it blurs distinctions between candidates and undermines the partisan mobilization that drives electoral success (Lee 2016). Politicians may also face cross-pressures from primary electorates and activists, who can be less favorable toward compromise than the general public (Anderson, Butler and Harbridge-Yong 2020; Hopkins, Lendway and Sigler 2025).

When politicians do express bipartisan intentions, the prevailing view is that these appeals do not credibly signal governing behavior. Existing studies find no clear link between bipartisan rhetoric and legislative action (Westwood 2022; Dobson, Volden and Wiseman 2025), reinforcing the view that bipartisan messaging is electioneering or "cheap talk." In this view, politicians use

bipartisan rhetoric to project moderation or independence when electoral success requires appealing to out-partisans, especially in competitive two-party districts (e.g., Trubowitz and Mellow 2005; Rhodes and Albert 2017). Formal models similarly demonstrate how electoral insecurity can induce bipartisan posturing, leading politicians to overstate their governing intentions to secure votes (e.g., Woon and Kanthak 2019; Kim, Lin and Schnakenberg 2024).

When politicians campaign as partisans but work across the aisle in office, their campaign rhetoric fails to convey the character of their legislative behavior. Conversely, when politicians make bipartisan campaign promises but fail to act on them, they misrepresent their governing intentions. In either case—whether bipartisanship is concealed or overstated—the democratic link between campaign claims and governing authority is weakened. Clarifying the relationship between bipartisan campaign promises and future legislative action, therefore, is crucial to understanding whether appeals to bipartisanship correspond to the coalition-building practices through which policy is enacted, or instead remain detached from the lawmaking process they purport to describe. Assessing this link depends, in part, on identifying the behavioral benchmark against which bipartisan campaign claims should be evaluated.

Bipartisanship as an Issue-Specific Commitment

We contend that existing work does not accurately capture the link between bipartisan appeals and legislative behavior because it assesses bipartisan rhetoric against a broad tendency for cross-party collaboration. Bipartisanship is typically conceived as a "legislative style," characterizing the extent to which a legislator engages with members of the opposing party. Under this conceptualization, some legislators are inherently more disposed to cross-party collaboration than others. This baseline tendency is thought to arise from legislator characteristics (e.g., Porter, Harden and Dobson 2025), district pressures (e.g., Harbridge and Malhotra 2011; Porter, Kakenmaster and Francis 2025), and institutional environments (e.g., Harbridge 2015; Case and Ommundsen 2024).

Yet campaign appeals to bipartisanship may operate quite differently, reflecting a targeted commitment rather than a cooperative disposition. We argue that politicians adopt bipartisan appeals selectively within campaigns, signaling their willingness to work across the aisle on some

policy domains but not others. This reflects an instrumental orientation toward bipartisanship, with politicians treating cross-party appeals as meaningful signals of their collaborative approach to achieving certain policymaking goals. From this perspective, the relevant question is not whether politicians are broadly bipartisan in office, but whether cross-party lawmaking varies systematically across the policy domains tied to their bipartisan campaign appeals.

This policy-oriented framework for conceptualizing bipartisanship reflects the practical constraints legislators face in the policymaking process. Substantive bipartisan engagement is costly, requiring negotiation, strategic coordination, and sustained relationship-building with members of the opposing party—and lawmakers have limited time and resources to devote to these efforts (Curry and Roberts 2023; Fong and Florez 2024; Victor 2025; Ommundsen 2025). At the same time, politicians are strongly motivated to pursue bipartisanship because such cooperation is often the most viable path to legislative success (Curry and Lee 2020). Existing research finds that bipartisan legislators are especially effective lawmakers, experiencing higher rates of lawmaking success (Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023).

These constraints imply that bipartisan campaign appeals reflect purposeful decisions about where to allocate scarce collaborative capital. This expectation is consistent with Craig (2023), who shows that policy alignment fosters bipartisanship, as shared objectives make cooperation mutually advantageous for advancing policy. Accordingly, we anticipate that politicians *selectively* employ appeals to bipartisanship, directing them toward a finite set of policy domains in which they are most motivated to achieve policymaking success. Multiple factors likely shape which policy domains attract these appeals. Politicians may emphasize bipartisanship on topics that are personally important to them, issues that their constituents prioritize, or their party's "must-pass" legislative priorities. Despite the varied motivations underlying these choices, the observable implication for our theoretical framework remains the same: politicians deploy bipartisan campaign appeals selectively to signal their lawmaking behavior.

H1 Politicians exhibit greater bipartisan legislative engagement in policy domains where they employed bipartisan campaign appeals.

A null finding would be consistent with several alternative interpretations regarding the relationship between bipartisan campaign commitments and legislative behavior. First, bipartisan appeals may reflect a general legislative disposition—the tendency to be bipartisan across all policy domains. Second, politicians may conceal their orientation toward collaboration during campaigns yet still govern collaboratively once in office. Third, politicians may fail to follow through on their bipartisan promises, employing them as electioneering tactics to attract voters. Conversely, greater bipartisan engagement in policy domains where politicians pledged cross-party collaboration suggests that these campaign appeals signal a legislator's collaborative approach to lawmaking.

Cross-party cooperation, however, can take multiple forms, ranging from substantive, serious collaboration to low-cost position-taking. Substantive bipartisan engagement involves meaningful participation in crafting legislation within cross-party coalitions (Curry and Roberts 2023). Such "workhorse" activities include developing bill content, negotiating compromises, and coordinating with stakeholders to prepare legislation for introduction. Yet bipartisan engagement can also occur after substantive drafting and negotiations are complete, serving primarily as an endorsement of the legislation (Koger 2003) or as a means for position-taking (Mayhew 1974; Kessler and Krehbiel 1996). This "show horse" approach to bipartisanship aligns with the superficial forms of follow-through emphasized in existing scholarship. Politicians fear being held accountable for their campaign promises, even when voters and other attentive observers do not punish them for failing to deliver. This concern may lead them to do just enough to claim they kept their word, rather than engage in the costly, hard work of substantive collaboration.

We contend that if politicians treat bipartisan campaign appeals as genuine commitments made instrumentally to advance legislative goals, they should engage in workhorse forms of collaboration. Substantive bipartisan labor is the form of cross-party engagement that meaningfully propels legislation toward passage (Curry and Roberts 2023). This is also the form of representation voters value most, as they prioritize substantive cooperation over symbolic gestures (Butler et al. 2023; Strickler 2024). Accordingly, we expect legislators to demonstrate greater substantive bipartisan involvement on issues where they make bipartisan appeals.

H2 Politicians exhibit greater substantive bipartisan legislative engagement in policy domains where they employ bipartisan campaign appeals.

Evidence that bipartisan appeals predict substantive collaboration but not low-cost, position-taking forms of bipartisan engagement would further support this expectation. Such a pattern would indicate that legislators are investing their finite time and energy where it matters most rather than satisfying their bipartisan commitments through superficial gestures. It would also be consistent with the logic that these modes of engagement are not jointly producible: a legislator cannot embody both a workhorse and a show horse role on the same piece of legislation.

Within our theoretical framework, bipartisan appeals highlight the policy domains in which lawmakers are most motivated to invest in cross-party collaboration and build the necessary coalitions to achieve legislative victories. Substantive bipartisan engagement should, therefore, correspond to more frequent legislative success in relevant policy domains. Conversely, if bipartisan appeals are mere rhetoric—or if substantive collaboration fails to translate into tangible outcomes—we would observe no relationship between substantive bipartisan engagement and legislative success. A null finding would suggest that either politicians' bipartisan appeals are not instrumental or that collaboration is insufficient to overcome barriers to passage.

H3 Politicians will achieve greater legislative success in policy domains where they exhibit substantive bipartisan engagement.

Identifying & Measuring Bipartisan Behavior

Our measurement strategy conceptualizes bipartisanship as a selective approach to campaign communication and, by extension, to lawmaking. We identify the issue priorities associated with bipartisan appeals in candidates' campaign agendas. We then examine whether the policy domains associated with these appeals correspond to variation in legislators' cross-party behavior.

Bipartisan Messaging in Campaigns

To measure candidates' bipartisan campaign messaging, we analyze the campaign platforms on congressional candidates' websites. These sites provide unmediated statements of candidates'

policy priorities (Druckman, Kifer and Parkin 2009). Because candidates strategically tailor website issue content (e.g., Porter, Treul and McDonald 2023; Case 2027; Case and Porter 2025), these platforms provide insight into campaign strategy rather than serving as static repositories or echoes of party-aligned positions. Website priorities also tend to align with those communicated through speeches, debates, and advertisements (Xenos and Foot 2005; Sulkin, Moriarty and Hefner 2007). Unlike social media, campaign websites impose no length limits, allowing candidates to present issue agendas with greater breadth and depth.

We analyze a corpus of campaign platforms compiled by Porter, Case and Treul (2025), covering candidates for the U.S. House of Representatives in the 2018, 2020, and 2022 elections. The dataset includes 75% of all major-party contenders who appeared on the ballot in primaries during these cycles (N = 4,507).[1] We assign each platform point to one of thirteen broad policy domains (e.g., healthcare, education, or immigration), allowing us to identify which policy domains candidates frame in bipartisan terms.[2] The full list of thirteen policy codes is available in Appendix A.

We classify platform points as bipartisan using a supervised machine learning pipeline. To train and test our classifiers, we manually labeled a random sample of 4,300 documents, coding each for the presence of bipartisan messaging. Coders were instructed to evaluate the overall quality of texts as bipartisan, rather rely on the presence of specific words or phrases. Appendix B provides hand-labeling instructions and inter-coder reliability assessments. We trained several machine learning models on 3,900 documents and selected the best-performing XGBoost classifier, which achieves an F1 score of 0.89 on a held-out sample of 400 hand-coded documents. Details on model tuning and performance, as well as text preprocessing, are available in Appendix B.

In Table 1, we present example platform points illustrating a range of bipartisan appeals made by incumbent and non-incumbent candidates. Notably, these appeals typically reference policy areas in general terms rather than specific legislative proposals.[3] This pattern is consistent with

[1]Platforms were collected immediately before each candidate's primary election. These texts reflect overall campaign messaging, as campaign websites tend to remain stable across stages (Porter, Treul and McDonald 2023).

[2]For additional details on assignment and validation procedures, see Porter, Case and Treul (2025).

[3]Through manual review of all platform points identified as bipartisan by our machine learning classifier, we find that over half invoke bipartisan cooperation within a policy area without naming a specific legislative proposal. For transparency, the online replication materials include the platform-point text and hand-labeled categorizations.

Table 1: Example Campaign Platform Points Classified as Bipartisan

Candidate	Statement Text
Jimmy Panetta (D-CA, 2020)	Policy Domain: *Energy & Environment* "In Congress, Jimmy is fighting to protect the Monterey Bay National Marine Sanctuary, as well as the California Coastal and other National Monuments from downsizing or elimination. **Jimmy is working with both sides of the aisle to promote environmental stewardship** and fight for policies that protect the Central Coast."
Mike Bost (R-IL, 2022)	Policy Domain: *Social Welfare* "Those counting on Social Security and Medicare should not have to worry about the promises that were made to them are kept...**Congress must work together to prevent the financial collapse of these programs by promoting bipartisan efforts** to address systemic problems and ensure its longevity for current and future generations."
Levii Shocklee (D-TX, 2018)	Policy Domain: *Healthcare* "Quality, affordable health care is a right and should be available for ALL Americans. **I intend to work, in a bipartisan fashion, to ensure that the citizens of the 6th district are heard regarding Health Care.** I will work to ensure that the cost of health care is reduced for individuals and families struggling with high premiums."

Note: Policy domains were pre-assigned by Porter, Case and Treul (2025). Texts were intentionally selected to demonstrate variation in bipartisan messaging across parties, policy domains, and communication styles. Randomly selected documents for face validation are presented in Appendix Table C.1.

prior work showing that campaign rhetoric often takes the form of broad appeals—for example, candidates presenting themselves as "champions for education" or "tough on crime" (Stokes 1992; Sides 2006; Sulkin, Moriarty and Hefner 2007; Sulkin 2009, 2011). The structure of these appeals aligns with our use of broad policy-domain classifications (e.g., *Energy & Environment*, *Social Welfare*, and *Healthcare*) to locate bipartisan rhetoric within candidates' campaign agendas.

Validating text-to-measure pipelines is essential for establishing construct recovery (Grimmer and Stewart 2013; Park and Montgomery 2025). Appendix C presents three validation exercises for our measurement of bipartisan campaign appeals. First, we show six randomly selected campaign platform documents alongside their model-generated classifications to demonstrate face validity (Appendix Table C.1). Second, we report the 30 highest-weighted word features from the classification model (Appendix Table C.2). The prominence of terms such as "bipartisan,"

"together," and "aisle" indicates that the classifier is recovering the intended construct. Third, we examine predictive validity by comparing bipartisan rhetoric among incumbents in the Congressional Problem Solvers Caucus—an expressly bipartisan caucus—to rhetoric among other incumbents (Appendix Section C.1). Caucus members are significantly more likely to use bipartisan campaign messaging and devote a larger share of their platforms to bipartisan themes ($p < 0.001$).

Bipartisan Lawmaking in Congress

To determine whether politicians fulfill their bipartisan campaign commitments, we adopt an agenda-based view of promise-keeping. We measure whether legislators' bipartisan engagement in office is concentrated in the policy domains where they made bipartisan appeals as candidates. We operationalize this form of follow-through using bill sponsorship and cosponsorship, defined as the introduction of a bill by a legislator and its formal endorsement by a colleague, respectively. Sponsorship and cosponsorship are voluntary forms of legislative participation that reveal the policy priorities members aim to promote, independent of most party and agenda-setting pressures (Highton and Rocca 2005; Sulkin 2009; Finocchiaro and MacKenzie 2024).[4] Lawmakers cannot meaningfully engage on every potential issue due to limited time and resources, making sponsorship and cosponsorship decisions necessarily selective. Importantly, bills with cross-party cosponsorships are more likely to advance through the legislative process (Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023), prompting members to seek or offer cross-party support to increase a bill's chances of becoming law (Curry and Roberts 2023; Craig 2023). These dynamics emphasize sponsorship and cosponsorship as central indicators of both policy commitment and bipartisan cooperation.

Yet not all sponsorship and cosponsorship behaviors signal equal commitment to bipartisan lawmaking. Among these actions, bill introduction is particularly significant, as it credibly signals a legislator's substantive commitment to advancing specific policy priorities (Schiller 1995). Although legislation is drafted primarily through collaborative efforts, congressional rules limit bills to a single

[4]Roll-call voting provides an alternative measure of bipartisan follow-through (see Westwood 2022). Such behavior, however, is constrained entirely by agenda setting and party discipline, as most bills never receive a roll-call vote and those that do may not reflect a legislator's own priorities (Cox and McCubbins 1993, 2005). These selection effects obscure legislators' proactive efforts to advance policy.

sponsor. Original cosponsorship, however, offers a signal of who else participated in the initial work of drafting legislation. Members who cosponsor a bill on the day it is introduced—known as original cosponsors—are recognized as committed partners in the bill's development, often perceived as co-equal coauthors of the bill. Such cosponsorships are rarely withdrawn, demonstrating a non-trivial commitment to the co-signed legislation (Bernhard and Sulkin 2013). According to Curry and Roberts (2023), bills with bipartisan original cosponsorships are "seen as a serious and bipartisan legislative effort by actors on the Hill, in part because it is a signal that legislators on both sides of the aisle collaborated to produce it" (p. 342). Following existing work (e.g., Curry and Roberts 2023, 2025; Porter, Harden and Dobson 2025), we use bill sponsorship and original cosponsorship to measure substantive cross-party collaboration.

While each bill has only one sponsor and typically a handful of original cosponsors, non-original cosponsors are numerous and can join at any stage of the legislative process before a bill receives a vote. Existing work characterizes non-original cosponsorships as a form of "bandwagoning," in which members sign on after observing colleagues' reactions and assessing a bill's prospects (Kessler and Krehbiel 1996; Wilson and Young 1997), or as low-cost position-taking (Koger 2003; Curry and Roberts 2023). For these reasons, we consider a non-original cosponsorship to be a weaker, less costly indicator of bipartisan legislative engagement.

We use the Congress.gov API to compile data on all bill sponsorship and cosponsorship activity in the 116th, 117th, and 118th Congresses. Our dataset consists of two relational structures: bill-sponsor pairings and bill-cosponsor pairings. We also gather information on the timing of cosponsorship to differentiate between original and non-original cosponsors. Finally, we rely on Congressional Research Service policy-domain classifications, which capture each bill's primary subject matter. These codes align with our thirteen policy-domain classifications of campaign platforms, allowing us to compare bipartisan appeals with relevant legislative activity.[5]

[5]In Appendix A, we provide greater detail on the correspondence between campaign platform topic codes and legislative policy codes.

Do Candidates Link Bipartisan Appeals to Issue Priorities?

Before evaluating whether the issue priorities candidates frame in bipartisan terms correspond with patterns of cross-party legislative behavior, we must first establish that candidates make bipartisan appeals in their campaign platforms. Existing research suggests that such appeals are infrequent in congressional campaigns, but this work relies on evidence that is often indirect, narrow in coverage, or removed from candidates' own campaign rhetoric. As a result, the basic prevalence of bipartisan messaging in congressional campaigns remains unresolved. Moreover, to our knowledge, no existing work examines whether candidates vary their use of bipartisan appeals across policy domains. If candidates adopt bipartisan language uniformly in their campaign agendas, our framework of bipartisanship as a selective signal of collaborative lawmaking would lack empirical grounding.

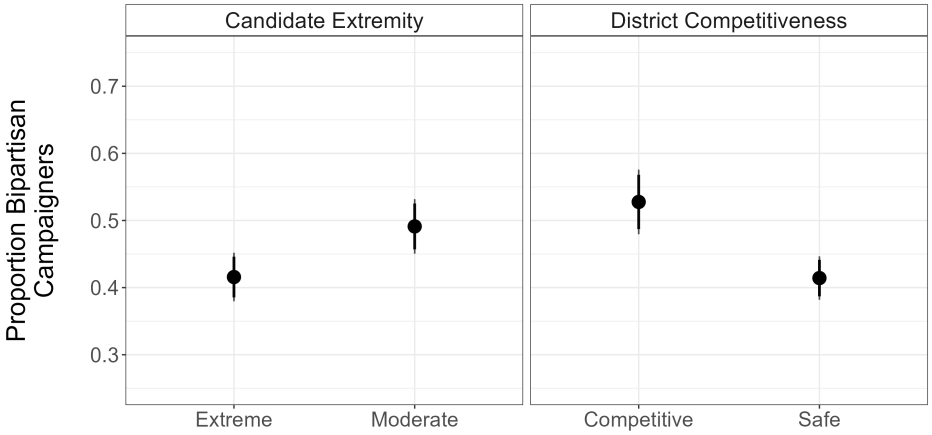
The descriptive analyses below address these two prerequisites. First, we establish that bipartisan appeals are common in congressional campaigns, even in conditions where the existing literature suggests they should be relatively rare. Second, we show that bipartisan messaging is a selective feature of campaign rhetoric, with most candidates emphasizing bipartisanship across only one or two issue priorities. Although individual candidates are selective about adoption of bipartisan language, bipartisan appeals across candidates span the full range of policy domains present in our data, including those commonly regarded as highly partisan.

Bipartisan Messaging Across Candidates

We begin by assessing the overall tendency of candidates elected to the U.S. House of Representatives to employ bipartisan messaging in their campaign platforms.[6] We define a candidate in a given election cycle as a bipartisan campaigner if we identify any of their platform points as containing bipartisan rhetoric. Using this approach, we find that bipartisan messaging is a relatively common campaign strategy. About 45% of incoming members of Congress between 2018 and 2022

[6]To evaluate the follow through of lawmakers acting on their campaign promises, we restrict our analyses to candidates who won their election.

Figure 1: Prevalence of Bipartisan Campaign Messaging by Candidate Ideology and District Competitiveness



Note: Units include all general election winners in U.S. House elections from 2018 to 2022. Bipartisan campaigners are defined as candidates with at least one platform point containing bipartisan appeals. Extreme (moderate) candidates fall above (below) their party's mean CFScore. Competitive districts have an average two-party presidential margin of victory over the previous three presidential elections of less than 15 percentage points. Vertical bounds indicate 95% confidence intervals.

employed such messaging, rising to 50% among incumbents seeking reelection.[7]

Next, we examine whether the prevalence of bipartisan messaging varies systematically across candidates. Existing work highlights two groups as especially likely to adopt bipartisan appeals: ideological moderates and candidates in competitive districts (Trubowitz and Mellow 2005; Rhodes and Albert 2017). Moderates may emphasize bipartisanship to reinforce their ideological brand, signaling to voters that their centrist positions reflect a commitment to cross-party cooperation.[8] Similarly, candidates in competitive districts may adopt bipartisan appeals to signal cross-party openness and broaden their electoral base in closely contested races. If legislators communicate bipartisan intentions only under these specific conditions, such appeals are less likely to reflect genuine policymaking commitments and, instead, likely function as electioneering tactics.

Figure 1 plots the average proportion of bipartisan campaigners across the 2018–2022 elections, by candidate extremity (extreme versus moderate) in the left panel and district competitiveness (competitive versus safe) in the right panel. We consider candidates to be extreme (moderate) if their

[7]In Appendix Table D.1, we assess potential predictors for bipartisan campaigner status for all major-party, primary election candidates who ran between 2018 and 2022.

[8]Alternatively, candidates may employ bipartisan messages to demonstrate issue-specific moderation rather than general moderate tendencies. We address this possibility in Appendix Section D.1 and find it unsupported.

CFScore, as calculated by Bonica (2024), is larger (smaller) in magnitude than their party mean.[9] We consider a district to be competitive if its average two-party presidential margin of victory over the previous three presidential elections is less than 15 percentage points.[10]

We find that moderates are somewhat more likely to adopt bipartisan appeals into their campaign platforms than extreme candidates (49.5% versus 41.9%), and candidates running in competitive districts are more likely to do so than those in safe districts (52.8% versus 41.9%). Although t-tests indicate that these differences are statistically significant, the magnitudes of difference are substantively modest. What is evident is that bipartisan appeals are prevalent even among ideologically extreme candidates and candidates running in safe districts. Taken together, these patterns suggest that bipartisan messaging is not confined to particular candidate types or electoral contexts, but is instead broadly adopted in congressional campaigns.

Bipartisan Messaging Across Policy Domains

We next assess whether candidates vary their use of bipartisan messaging across the policy domains they discuss within their campaign platforms. If candidates reserve bipartisan appeals for only some areas of their campaign agendas, this would indicate that such rhetoric serves as a targeted signal. To examine this selectivity, we focus on bipartisan campaigners: candidates elected to the U.S. House who employ bipartisan rhetoric in at least one campaign platform point. Among these candidates, we examine all issue priorities in their campaign platforms and consider a policy domain bipartisan if any corresponding platform point includes bipartisan rhetoric.[11]

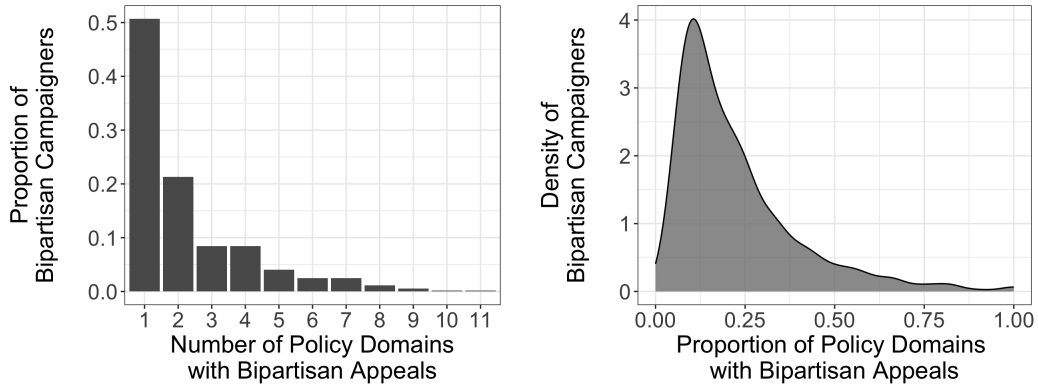
Figure 2 shows how extensively bipartisan campaigners incorporate bipartisan appeals into their platforms. The left panel reports the number of policy domains in which candidates employ bipartisan appeals; the right panel reports the share of each candidate's platform containing bipartisan messaging, accounting for variation in platform breadth (i.e., the number of policy domains a candidate discusses). About half of bipartisan campaigners use such appeals on a single policy

[9] Altering the cutoff to stricter definitions of ideological extremity (e.g., a third of a standard deviation more extreme than their party's mean) produces substantively similar results.

[10] Altering cutoffs (e.g., to 10-percentage-point) produces substantively identical results.

[11] Although candidates' platforms may include multiple platform points, several often address the same policy domain. If any of these points include bipartisan rhetoric, we consider the domain to be bipartisan.

Figure 2: Pervasiveness of Bipartisan Messaging in Campaign Platforms



Note: Plots display the distribution of the number (left) and proportion (right) of policy domains in which candidates employ bipartisan messages. Bipartisan campaigners are defined as candidates with at least one platform point containing bipartisan appeals.

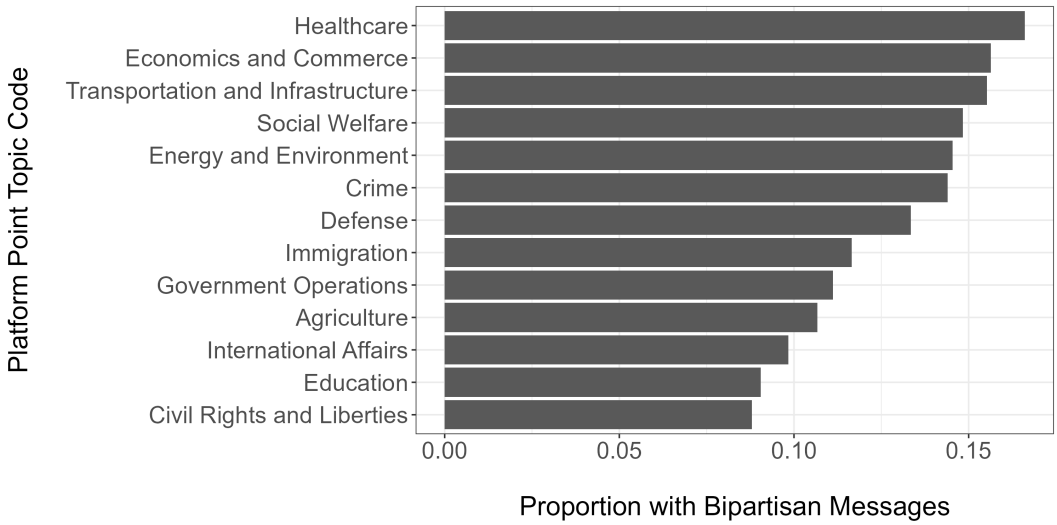
domain, and fewer than 15% extend them to more than half of their platform. Overall, we find that the broad use of bipartisan appeals is rare.

We next examine which policy domains candidates present in bipartisan terms. One possibility is that bipartisan messaging is concentrated in distributive or consensus-oriented policy domains rather than in areas commonly associated with partisan conflict. If so, bipartisan appeals would provide limited insight into legislative behavior in contentious areas, where cross-party collaboration is often most consequential to achieving policymaking success. To evaluate this possibility, we examine how bipartisan messaging varies across the thirteen policy domains in our data. For each policy domain, we calculate the share of candidates who use bipartisan messaging, conditional on discussing that domain.[12]

Figure 3 presents the prevalence of bipartisan rhetoric within each policy domain, with domains ordered from the highest to the lowest rate of bipartisan messaging. As expected, policy domains that more often see bipartisan engagement within Congress, such as distributive topics like *Transportation and Infrastructure*, display relatively high rates of bipartisan messaging in campaign platforms (15.5%). Yet several contentious areas show similarly high levels. Policy domains like *Healthcare* (16.6%), *Energy and Environment* (14.5%), and *Crime* (14.4%) all exhibit

[12]Candidates demonstrate considerable selectivity in which issues they emphasize: on average, they address only seven of the thirteen policy domains per election cycle.

Figure 3: Bipartisan Messaging in Campaign Platforms by Policy Domain



Note: Proportions are calculated among candidates who addressed a given issue area; the numerator is the number whose platform point(s) on that issue included bipartisan messaging.

substantial bipartisan messaging among candidates who discuss these topics. Some especially partisan issues, such as *Civil Rights and Liberties*, show lower rates of bipartisan appeals, yet nearly 9% of candidates who address this area still deploy them.

The analyses above show that elected officials are willing to communicate bipartisan intentions, even in contexts where prior work suggests such messaging should be uncommon. When candidates make bipartisan appeals, they are selective, targeting only a few policy domains rather than their entire platforms. Importantly, this selectivity does not mean that bipartisan messaging clusters within a minority of policy areas. The selective nature of these appeals raises an important question for democratic representation and accountability: when candidates attach bipartisan commitments to specific policy domains during campaigns, do they follow through with bipartisan legislative action on those same domains once in office?

Do Bipartisan Commitments Correspond to Cross-Party Lawmaking?

We now investigate whether legislators' bipartisan campaign appeals translate into legislative action. If campaign messaging conveys credible signals of collaborative priorities, bipartisan cooperation should occur in policy domains where legislators emphasize such commitments during campaigns. We approach this inquiry in two parts. First, we assess whether legislators who make

bipartisan appeals on certain policy domains later sponsor and cosponsor a greater share of bipartisan bills on those domains. Second, we assess whether bipartisan commitments lead to substantive, "workhorse" cross-party collaboration or weaker "show horse" bipartisan engagement. We focus on U.S. House members during the 116th, 117th, and 118th Congresses. Units of analysis are member-Congress-policy combinations, yielding thirteen observations per member-Congress.[13]

Bipartisan Appeals and Legislative Engagement Across Policy Domains

To assess patterns of legislative activity, we analyze the sponsorship and cosponsorship of bipartisan bills, which we term bipartisan bill engagement. We define a bipartisan bill as a piece of legislation that includes at least one Democrat and one Republican as a sponsor and/or original cosponsor.[14] Because these collaborators serve as substantive partners in drafting legislation, this definition establishes that the bill's authorship embodies bipartisan intent. We measure bipartisan bill engagement as the share of a member's sponsorship and original cosponsorship activity in a given policy domain that occurs on bipartisan bills. This measure captures how members allocate their bipartisan legislative efforts, accounting for member-specific variation in volume of engagement. Member-Congress-policy observations with no sponsorship or cosponsorship activity are assigned zero, reflecting the absence of bipartisan engagement in that policy domain.[15] We use fractional logit regressions, most appropriate for proportional outcomes.[16]

Our key explanatory variable is a three-level factor capturing messaging in the previous election, with categories indicating whether candidates: (1) campaigned on the policy domain *with* bipartisan messaging, (2) campaigned on the domain *without* bipartisan messaging, or (3) *did not* campaign on the domain. This distinction is consequential because politicians seek to fulfill campaign promises (Sulkin 2009, 2011), which may induce cross-party collaboration on all policy domains within their

[13]For example, Elise Stefanik (R-NY)–116th Congress–*Immigration*.

[14]Defining bipartisan bills as those including at least one Democrat and one Republican as a sponsor and/or *any* cosponsor produces substantively identical results.

[15]One concern is that this may conflate pure partisan legislative activity with legislative inattention, since both yield zero values for bipartisan bill engagement. To address this possibility, we replicate the main analyses after excluding member-Congress-policy observations in which legislators have no sponsorship or cosponsorship activity in the relevant domain. The results are substantively unchanged and reported in Appendix Tables E.1–E.2.

[16]Linear regressions produce substantively identical results (Appendix Tables F.1–F.2). Negative binomial regressions using count outcomes also produce similar results (Appendix Tables G.1–G.2), though these do not account for within-member variation in legislative effort across domains.

campaign platforms, not only those framed in explicitly bipartisan terms. Our aim is to determine whether bipartisan messaging generates even greater cross-party engagement beyond this tendency. Distinguishing among these types of campaign signals allows us to determine whether bipartisan messaging carries predictive power independent of issue attention.

We include a fixed effect for each member-Congress observation in our models to account for static member-level traits, time-varying member-level traits, and time-varying Congress-level traits. Put differently, these member-Congress fixed effects control for unobserved traits related to institutional dynamics (e.g., majority-party status, committee membership) and individual characteristics (e.g., ideological moderation, legislative effectiveness) that may be static or vary across time. Importantly, these fixed effects also capture each member's general disposition towards bipartisan cooperation in an individual Congress. Thus, if bipartisanship reflects a general legislative disposition rather than a policy-oriented commitment, bipartisan campaigning on a particular policy domain should show no discernible association with subsequent bill engagement. We also include policy-Congress fixed effects to account for aggregate variation in bipartisan collaboration across policy domains. As with our member-Congress fixed effects, our policy-Congress fixed effects account for both static and dynamic policy-area traits related to bipartisan legislating.

Table 2 presents model results, which support our follow-through hypothesis (H1). Compared to policy domains in which candidates employ bipartisan appeals, issues without such appeals—or without any campaign platform attention—exhibit significantly lower levels of bipartisan engagement, as reflected by negative coefficients.[17] To interpret these results, Figure 4 displays the predicted marginal effects of campaign messaging on bipartisan bill engagement, holding member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. This plot reveals how the proportion of bipartisan bill engagement changes relative to the reference category (bipartisan messaging). Predicted values reflect within-member-Congress comparisons across policy domains

[17]The bivariate relationship between campaign messaging and subsequent bipartisan bill engagement is consistent with our expectations. Member-Congress-policy observations where candidates campaigned on an issue with bipartisan messaging have an average bipartisan bill engagement rate of 54.9%, compared to 48.3% among observations where candidates campaigned on the issue without bipartisan messaging and 51.1% among observations where candidates did not campaign on the issue. The proportion for bipartisan campaigners is significantly different from both the non-bipartisan campaigner and non-campaigner categories at the 0.01 level.

Table 2: Bipartisan Messaging & Bipartisan Legislative Engagement

Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Dependent Variable: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement
No Bipartisan Messaging	-0.081^{***}
vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	(0.031)
No Messaging	-0.065^{**}
vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	(0.032)
Observations	14,833
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓

Note: Model specification is a fractional logit. Linear specification is available in Appendix Table E.1. Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Bipartisan bill engagement measures the proportion of bills sponsored or cosponsored by a legislator that include at least one Democrat and one Republican among the original cosponsorship coalition. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

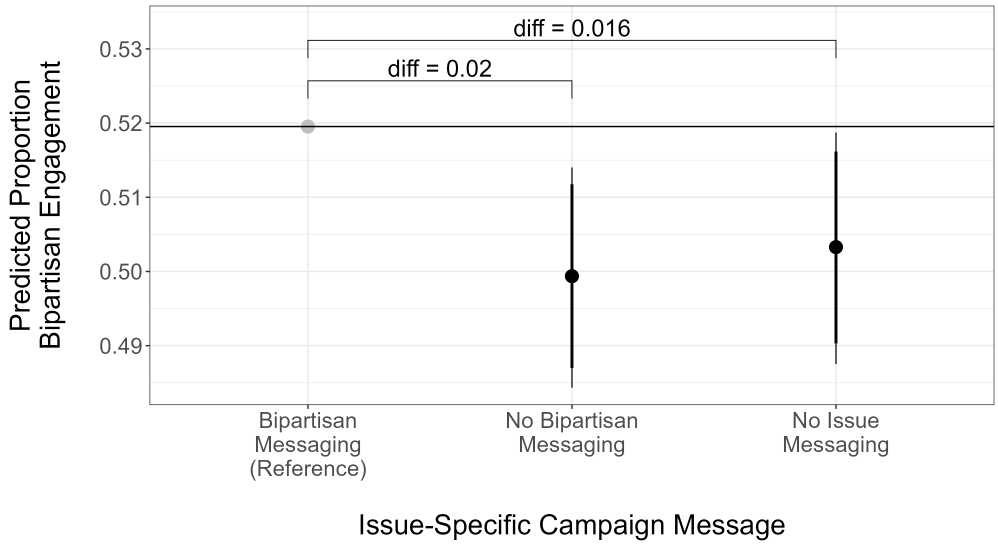
based on messaging behavior, while accounting for aggregate differences in cross-domain bipartisan engagement. We find that, on average, legislators allocate 2 percentage points more of their sponsorship and cosponsorship activity to bipartisan bills in policy domains they campaigned on with bipartisan messaging than to those they addressed in their platforms without such messaging. They allocate 1.8 percentage points more engagement to bipartisan bills in policy domains they campaigned on with bipartisan messaging, compared to those they did not address.

Although these effects meet conventional significance thresholds, they are substantively modest. This likely reflects the constraints of a highly polarized legislative environment in which even small movements toward cross-party cooperation can represent meaningful change. Additionally, these results aggregate across all forms of bipartisan engagement. Because we expect bipartisan messaging to primarily encourage workhorse collaboration, aggregate measurement may obscure these effects. We disaggregate bipartisan engagement in the following analyses to test whether campaign messaging differentially affects distinct types of engagement.

Bipartisan Appeals and Substantive Engagement Across Policy Domains

We now examine the relationship between bipartisan campaign commitments and bipartisan legislative engagement, distinguishing substantive "workhorse" collaboration from lower-cost

Figure 4: Predicted Bipartisan Engagement by Campaign Messaging Behavior



Note: Predicted values reflect within-member-Congress comparisons across issues based on messaging behavior, holding member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. Vertical bounds indicate 90% and 95% confidence intervals.

"show horse" cooperation. We define substantive bipartisan bill engagement as the sponsorship or original cosponsorship of a bill alongside at least one member of the opposing party. This stricter definition captures whether a legislator belongs to the bipartisan coalition responsible for authoring and introducing bills. Low-cost, show horse bipartisan bill engagement constitutes non-original cosponsorship on bipartisan bills.[18]

Table 3 presents model results, which support our substantive engagement hypothesis (H2). The outcome in the left column is workhorse, substantive bipartisan engagement (sponsorship/original cosponsorship), and the outcome in the right column is show horse bipartisan bill engagement (non-original cosponsorship). Consistent with H2, legislators engage in less bipartisan bill sponsorship and original cosponsorship in policy domains they either campaigned on without bipartisan messaging or did not campaign on at all, relative to domains they campaigned on using bipartisan appeals. In other words, when members make bipartisan appeals in a policy domain, they are more likely to pursue and actively participate in bipartisan legislative efforts in that domain than in domains absent from their platforms or discussed without bipartisan appeals.

[18]We again define bipartisan bills as those including at least one Democrat and one Republican as a sponsor and/or original cosponsor.

Table 3: Bipartisan Messaging & Bipartisan Legislative Engagement by Engagement Type

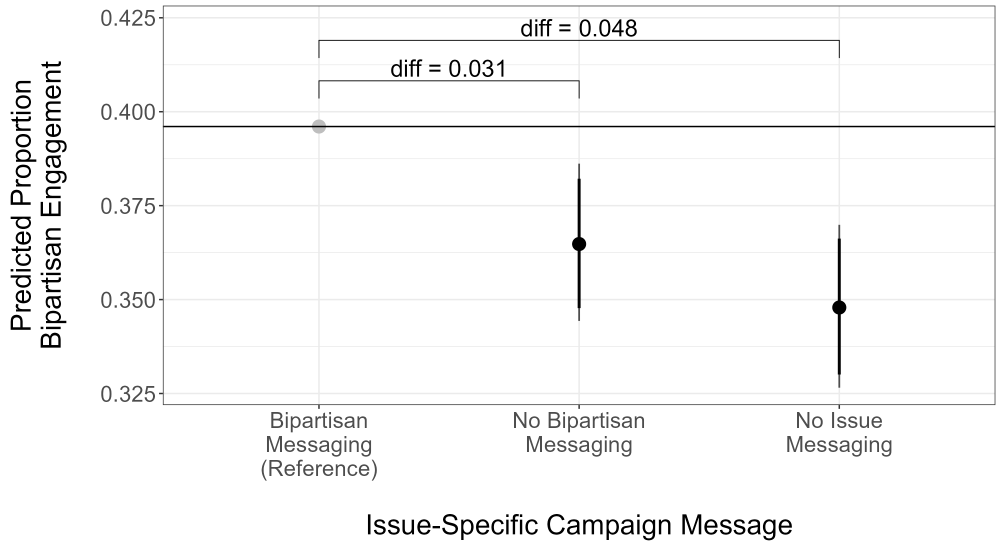
	Dependent variable: Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	
Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Sponsor/Orig. Cosponsor	Non-Original Cosponsor
No Bipartisan Messaging	-0.133^{***}	-0.037
vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	(0.046)	(0.036)
No Messaging	-0.207^{***}	-0.060
vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	(0.048)	(0.039)
Observations	14,833	14,833
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

Note: Model specification is a fractional logit. Linear specification is available in Appendix Table E.2. Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

In contrast, show horse bipartisan engagement shows no significant differences across campaign messaging categories. These divergent patterns suggest bipartisan campaign rhetoric specifically motivates costly forms of cross-party collaboration—drafting and introducing legislation—while routine cosponsorship behavior remains stable regardless of campaign messaging. This aligns with our expectation that bipartisan appeals serve as selective, credible commitments to engage in the more demanding forms of cross-party collaboration that are necessary to advance bills through the legislative process and achieve lawmaking success. It also aligns with the reality that both types of bill engagement are not jointly producible: a legislator cannot simultaneously embody both a workhorse and a show horse role on the same bill.

To interpret these results, Figure 5 displays the predicted marginal effects of campaign messaging on substantive bipartisan bill engagement, holding member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. This plot reveals how the proportion of bipartisan bill engagement changes relative to the reference category (bipartisan messaging). We find that, on average, legislators allocate 3.1 percentage points more of their sponsorship and original cosponsorship activity to bipartisan bills in policy domains they campaigned on with bipartisan messaging than to those they addressed in their campaign platforms without such messaging. Legislators allocate 4.8

Figure 5: Predicted Substantive Bipartisan Engagement by Campaign Messaging Behavior



Note: Predicted values reflect within-member-Congress comparisons across issues based on messaging behavior, holding member-Congress and policy-area-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. Substantive bipartisan bill engagement measures the proportion of issue-specific bills sponsored and/or originally cosponsored by a legislator that include at least one Democrat and one Republican among the original cosponsorship coalition. Vertical bounds indicate 90% and 95% confidence intervals.

percentage points more of their substantive legislative effort to bipartisan bills in policy domains they campaigned on with bipartisan messaging, compared to those they did not address.

These effect sizes are substantively meaningful, particularly amid contemporary polarization. To contextualize the magnitude of these effects, we benchmark them against majority-minority status and legislator ideology—widely considered among the strongest predictors of bipartisan engagement. Bipartisanship aids all legislators in advancing bills (Curry and Lee 2020; Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023), but is especially crucial for minority-party members who depend on majority cooperation to move any legislation forward. Bipartisanship is, therefore, essential to the success of minority-party legislators. Ideological moderates may also engage more readily across party lines due to greater policy overlap with the opposition (The Lugar Center 2025). Consistent with these expectations, minority party members and ideological moderates in our data dedicate a significantly greater share of their aggregate legislative activity to bipartisan bills.

Drawing from the model presented in Table 3 (left column), the estimated effect of bipartisan messaging versus no bipartisan messaging is equivalent to 79% of the majority-minority difference

in bipartisan engagement. In other words, the boost in substantive engagement from campaigning on a policy domain with bipartisan appeals approaches the difference between being in the minority versus being in the majority party. The effect size also equals 66% of the effect of a half-standard deviation decrease in ideological extremity, meaning that bipartisan campaign messaging rivals that of being a substantially more moderate legislator. The effect of bipartisan messaging versus no messaging is even larger, equaling 123% and 102% of these benchmarks, respectively.

These findings reveal that bipartisan campaign messaging meaningfully predicts subsequent legislative behavior for substantive collaboration rather than low-cost engagement. This targeted increase in costly collaboration suggests campaign rhetoric functions as a credible signal of legislative priorities in pursuit of policymaking success, rather than mere position-taking. The absence of effects for non-original cosponsorship indicates that bipartisan appeals do not reflect a general propensity for cross-party engagement. Instead, legislators invest in collaborative efforts in the policy domains in which they emphasized bipartisan problem-solving during the campaign.

Because our analysis is conducted at the policy-domain level, these results should be interpreted as evidence of correspondence between campaign issue priorities and related legislative activity. This level of aggregation reflects how bipartisan campaign commitments are typically articulated: as general policy-area commitments, such as pledges to "work across the aisle on healthcare" or "seek bipartisan solutions to immigration." To assess whether this policy-domain approach drives the results, we replicate the main analyses using a subset of narrower policy areas. Appendix Tables H.1–H.2 report the results, which are substantively similar to those presented in Tables 2–3.

Bipartisan Messages as Prospective Campaign Commitments

Our analyses thus far yield three key findings: (1) candidates employ bipartisan campaign appeals selectively; (2) these appeals serve as credible indicators of bipartisan legislative engagement in corresponding policy domains; and (3) bipartisan appeals predict increases in substantive, workhorse forms of bipartisan collaboration. Taken together, these results show that when candidates communicate bipartisan messages during campaigns, those messages function as selective and credible commitments to bipartisan legislating on corresponding policy domains.

These broad conclusions, however, rest on the assumption that campaign messages signal politicians' intended bipartisan behavior in the subsequent Congress. For incumbents seeking reelection, several alternative pathways could account for the observed association between campaign messaging and post-election action. Incumbents who emphasize bipartisanship on the campaign trail may be engaging in retrospective credit-claiming for prior legislative achievements, with subsequent bipartisan activity reflecting path dependence rather than campaign-induced commitments. Moreover, members frequently draw on established working relationships when assembling cross-party coalitions (Curry and Roberts 2023; Craig 2023; Victor 2025), so their bipartisan actions may arise from pre-existing partnerships and norms of reciprocity (Kirkland 2011) rather than from the signals conveyed during their campaigns.

To isolate the effect of campaign messaging on legislative behavior, we exploit the unique position of first-term legislators. Freshman members cannot invoke prior legislative accomplishments, eliminating retrospective credit-claiming as a potential confounder. Furthermore, the kinds of cross-party networks that facilitate bipartisan collaboration develop through repeated interactions over multiple congressional sessions—social capital that freshman legislators have not yet accumulated. This institutional constraint renders the bipartisan campaign appeals of freshman lawmakers analytically valuable: such messages constitute ex-ante commitments to bipartisan cooperation, unconditioned by established legislative records or pre-existing cross-party relationships. If retrospective credit-claiming or established networks drive our main results, we should observe null effects among freshmen. Conversely, if bipartisan messaging signals prospective commitments, the freshman subsample should yield effects comparable to those in Table 3.

Accordingly, we estimate the same models shown in the left column of Table 3, focusing on substantive bipartisan bill engagement among first-term legislators.[19] Table 4 presents model results. Compared to policy domains in which candidates employed bipartisan appeals, domains addressed without such appeals—or omitted from campaign platforms altogether—are associated

[19]Several newly elected individuals to the 116th, 117th, and 118th Congresses had served in the House in non-sequential Congresses prior the election of interest (e.g., Darrell Issa (R-CA) did not serve in the 116th Congress and was elected to the 117th Congress, but served in the 115th Congress as well as several other terms prior to his election to the 117th Congress). Removing these members yields identical results.

Table 4: Bipartisan Messaging & Substantive Legislative Engagement for First-Term Legislators

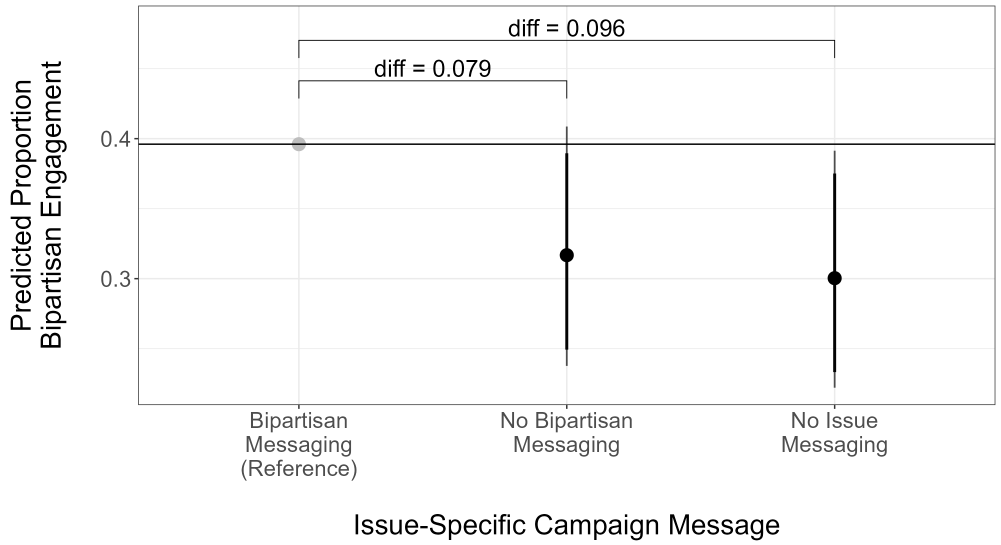
	Dependent Variable:
Policy Domain Campaign Message:	Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement
No Bipartisan Messaging	-0.353^{*}
vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	(0.203)
No Messaging	-0.432^{**}
vs. Campaigned with Bipartisan Messaging	(0.211)
Observations	2,496
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓

Note: Model specification is a fractional logit. Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Substantive bill engagement measures sponsorship and/or original cosponsorship for bipartisan legislation. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

with significantly lower levels of substantive bipartisan engagement among first-term lawmakers, as reflected in the negative coefficients. These findings are consistent with our prior results, which include all legislators and are presented in Table 3.

To interpret these results, Figure 6 displays the predicted marginal effects of campaign messaging on substantive bipartisan bill engagement, holding member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. This plot reveals how the proportion of bipartisan bill engagement for first-term lawmakers changes relative to the reference category (bipartisan messaging). We find that, on average, first-term legislators allocate 7.1 percentage points more of their sponsorship and original cosponsorship activity to bipartisan bills in policy domains where they employed bipartisan messaging, compared to those they adopted into their platforms without such messaging. Similarly, first-term legislators allocate 9.6 percentage points more of their substantive legislative engagement to bipartisan bills in policy domains where they adopted bipartisan messaging, compared to those they did not adopt into their platforms. These findings highlight that even among legislators without prior cross-party relationships or legislative histories, bipartisan campaign commitments translate to substantively meaningful increases in bipartisan lawmaking. These results support our view that bipartisan campaign appeals serve as credible prospective commitments.

Figure 6: Predicted Substantive Bipartisan Engagement of First-Term Legislators



Note: Substantive bipartisan bill engagement measures a legislator's issue-specific bill sponsorship and original cosponsorships on bipartisan legislation, out of all issue-specific bill engagement. We classify a bill as bipartisan if it includes at least one Democrat and one Republican as a sponsor and/or original cosponsor. Vertical bounds indicate 90% and 95% confidence intervals.

Does Substantive Bipartisan Collaboration Lead to Legislative Success?

Our theoretical framework argues that politicians treat bipartisan campaign appeals as credible, selective commitments made instrumentally to advance legislative goals. This strategic orientation reflects the reality that bipartisan coalition-building is often necessary for lawmaking success. Indeed, existing work demonstrates that bipartisan cooperation is predictive of lawmaking success (e.g., Curry and Roberts 2023; Craig 2023; Harbridge-Yong, Volden and Wiseman 2023). These studies, however, focus on bipartisanship as a stable orientation towards lawmaking, rather than a policy-oriented commitment. If bipartisan appeals reflect instrumental calculations about achieving meaningful legislative success, the payoff should be observable at the policy-domain level.[20]

To evaluate this component of our theory, we examine the relationship between substantive legislative engagement and policymaking success. The key explanatory variable is the proportion of

[20]The meaningfulness of legislative success can be assessed along two dimensions. The first concerns how far a bill advances through the lawmaking process. We focus on the most consequential outcomes—bill passage and enactment—though other work examines earlier stages of legislative progress (Dobson, Volden and Wiseman 2025). A second dimension concerns the substantive weight of the proposed policies. As we show in Appendix Table I.1, legislators tend to engage in substantive bipartisan collaboration on issues that are important to their districts. This distinction matters because it helps ensure that the bipartisan activity we observe is not merely performative follow-through, but reflects genuine efforts to advance policies that matter to their district.

Table 5: Legislative Success and Substantive Bipartisan Engagement

	Dependent variable: Proportion of a Legislator's Bill Engagement	
	Passed House	Becomes Law
Proportion of Bipartisan Bill Engagement	1.724***	2.533***
	(0.084)	(0.137)
Observations	16,275	14,322
Member-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Policy-Congress Fixed Effects	✓	✓

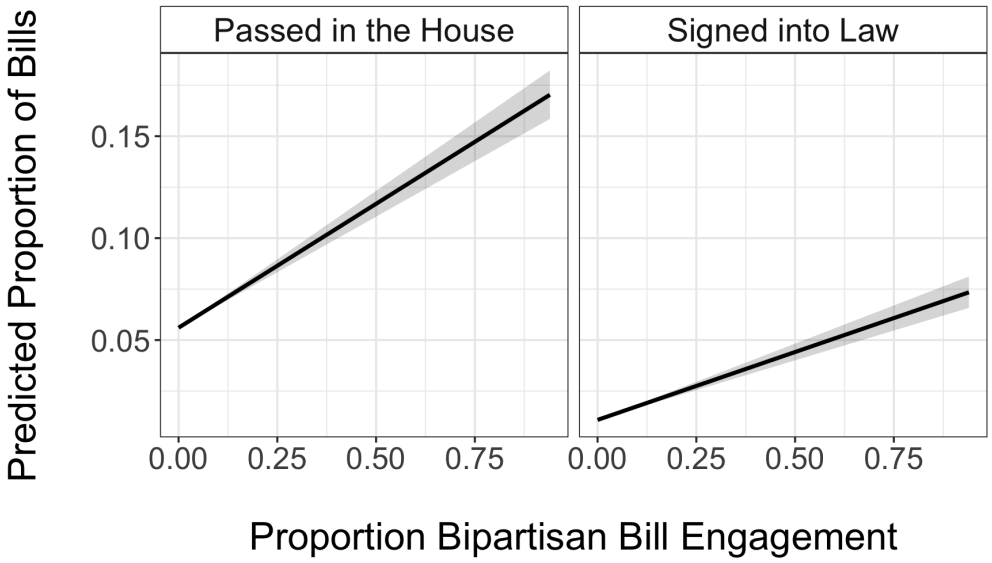
Note: Units are defined at the member-Congress-policy level. Differences in observation counts across columns reflect the exclusion of cases with no variation in the dependent variable. Clustered standard errors by member. *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01.

a legislator's substantive bill engagement that is bipartisan for a given policy domain. As above, we define this measure as the share of bills in which a legislator serves as a sponsor and/or an original cosponsor alongside at least one opposing-party member. The outcome variables indicate, for each policy domain, the proportion of a legislator's sponsored or originally cosponsored bills that (1) passed the House or (2) became law. Consistent with our previous analyses, we estimate the relationship between substantive bipartisan engagement and legislative outcomes using fractional logit models that include member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects.

Table 5 presents the model estimates, which are consistent with our policymaking success hypothesis (H3). Increases in a legislator's substantive bipartisan bill engagement are associated with higher proportions of their initiatives passing the House (left column) and being signed into law (right column) within that policy domain. In other words, as the proportion of a legislator's bill engagement becomes more bipartisan—that is, as a larger share of their substantive bill engagement is bipartisan—they experience greater policymaking success within that policy domain.

To interpret these results, Figure 7 displays the change in the predicted proportion of a legislator's policy-domain-related bills that pass the House (left panel) and become law (right panel) as a function of the proportion of relevant bipartisan bill engagement. Predicted values are generated holding member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. Both

Figure 7: Predicted Effects of Substantive Bipartisan Engagement on Bill Passage and Enactment



Note: Predicted values reflect within-member-Congress comparisons across issues based on the proportion of substantive bill engagement that is bipartisan, holding member-Congress and policy-Congress fixed effects at their observed mean values. Shaded regions indicate 95% confidence interval.

panels show a clear upward trajectory: as legislators devote a larger share of their policy-domain-related engagement to bipartisan collaboration, the likelihood that their bills advance through the legislative process increases. These patterns are consistent with the idea that engaging substantively with members of the opposing party facilitates coalition formation, increases legislative viability, and ultimately improves the prospects of bill passage and enactment. Taken together, these findings indicate that bipartisan engagement is associated with greater policymaking success in the policy domains aligned with legislators' campaign commitments, aligning with our theoretical expectations.

Conclusion

Do candidates invoke bipartisan commitments during campaigns, and do these messages translate into cooperation once in office? This paper provides evidence that such commitments function as credible signals of legislative behavior, deepening our understanding of representation in contemporary American politics. We introduce a novel theoretical perspective on bipartisanship, viewing it as a selective, policy-oriented commitment rather than a general approach to lawmaking. This conceptualization has broad implications for how we understand candidate strategy in elections

and the nuances of legislative follow-through. To test our theory, we connect virtually all available campaign platforms for U.S. House elections from 2018 to 2022 with legislative actions taken in the 116th, 117th, and 118th Congresses. This effort involved the supervised machine learning classification of 43,465 campaign statements and the collection of comprehensive data on legislative activity related to 28,648 introduced bills. Our approach fills a critical gap in the literature by providing the first comprehensive empirical test of whether candidates' campaign messages predict legislative behavior.[21]

Our findings demonstrate that bipartisan campaigning is common among candidates but is employed selectively within campaigns. About half of incumbents include bipartisan appeals in their platforms, but—consistent with our expectation that bipartisanship serves as a targeted messaging strategy—candidates typically focus these appeals on select policy domains. These findings add to an expanding body of research highlighting important nuances in how congressional candidates position themselves during campaigns (e.g., Case 2027; Case and Porter 2025; Bailey and Reese 2025). Future research should explore the complex calculations underlying these patterns, including how candidates decide which issues to frame in bipartisan terms, why certain policy areas tend to attract more cross-party appeals, and how electoral contexts influence these strategic decisions. The policy-driven and nuanced nature of bipartisan messaging offers valuable opportunities for scholars to analyze the micro-level strategic choices that determine when and how candidates call for cross-party cooperation during campaigns.

We find that legislators who make bipartisan appeals in specific policy domains during campaigns later engage in cross-party collaboration within those same areas. Disaggregating across types of collaboration, we demonstrate that bipartisan campaign messaging predicts substantive bipartisan action—bill sponsorship and original cosponsorship with colleagues across the aisle—rather than more symbolic, non-original cosponsorship. This "workhorse" pattern of collaboration persists even among first-term legislators who cannot claim credit for past bipartisan work or rely on established cross-party relationships, increasing confidence in the observed relationship between campaign

[21] Existing work evaluating the campaign-to-Congress connection rests on samples of candidates (e.g., Sulkin 2009), whereas our analysis covers virtually all members of the U.S. House in the 116th to 118th Congresses.

promises and legislative outcomes.

Our findings address key questions about representation and democratic accountability in American politics. There are two established perspectives on the link between bipartisan campaigning and governance: one argues that politicians avoid discussing compromise during elections, making their campaign messages unreliable indicators of future behavior; the other considers bipartisan appeals to be cheap talk aimed at influencing specific voters yet lacking tangible follow-through. We find support for neither conception. Our analyses, instead, show a clear link between campaign promises and legislative action: politicians who pledge bipartisan cooperation on certain issues follow through by delivering meaningful collaboration in those areas.

These findings carry significant implications for democratic theory and representative government. By demonstrating that bipartisan campaign appeals correspond to legislative behavior, this research affirms a central premise of promissory representation: campaign commitments are not merely electoral claims, but public obligations that elected officials are normatively expected to honor in office (Mansbridge 2003; Rehfeld 2009). This link is particularly consequential amid heightened polarization, where scholars have questioned whether campaigns illuminate or obscure the prospects for collaborative lawmaking. Our evidence challenges pessimistic accounts that bipartisan campaign rhetoric is purely strategic positioning divorced from governing conduct. Instead, we show that bipartisan commitments retain representative force in Congress, structuring the policy domains in which legislators engage in cross-party collaboration. Polarization, then, has not severed the campaign-to-Congress connection. Even within a deeply divided legislature, elected officials appear to act in ways consistent with the cooperative commitments they make on the campaign trail. Understanding these dynamics is essential for assessing the health of American democracy because democratic legitimacy depends not only on electoral competition, but also on whether representatives carry their public commitments into the exercise of governing authority.

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